

Austin ended its license plate reader program. Then the police department found a loophole.

KUT 90.5 | By [Andrew Weber](#)

Published February 12, 2026 at 2:07 PM CST



LISTEN • 6:51

Gabriel C. Pérez / KUT News

Austin police discontinued a program to use license plate readers, but they can still access data from other agencies.

Austin police are still using license plate reader technology months after the Austin City Council ended the city's program over privacy concerns.

A KUT investigation found the Austin Police Department accessed data from Flock Safety license plate readers maintained by neighboring law enforcement agencies.

within the last month. The access skirts the city's push to end the firm's presence in Austin — and highlights a gap in Austin's policies on surveillance technology.

The cameras scan license plates at intersections and allow police to search a database for certain criminal activity, like stolen cars or arrest warrants tied to certain vehicles.

Austin [ended its contract](#) with Flock last June after pushback from [residents who said](#) the [surveillance can be shared](#) with immigration enforcement and that the system can be used as a dragnet that leads to [wrongful arrests](#).



While APD no longer has the license plate reading cameras on city roads, it does have access to cameras maintained by at least two neighboring agencies: [Round Rock](#) and [Sunset Valley](#) police. Both agencies listed APD under the departments they had shared data with in the last 30 days. APD confirmed to KUT that they are able to request data from the other departments' cameras, but they don't have direct access to Flock systems.

"There may be situations where APD requests assistance from peer law enforcement agencies, such as during a joint investigation or when additional information is needed for investigative purposes," APD said. "These partnerships ensure the safety and well-

APD did not say whether it had accessed data from any other departments' license plate readers, including the Texas Department of Public Safety, which [recently installed](#) Flock cameras near its headquarters off North Lamar Boulevard.

Council Member Mike Siegel said the department's ability to access Flock's system is a "major gap" that goes against [guardrails set up](#) by the Austin City Council in 2023 that required city oversight and reports to city management when APD still had an active contract with Flock.

Last week, Council expanded on those protections with a sweeping surveillance measure called the Transparent and Responsible Use of Technology (TRUST) Act.

"Although use of other agencies [license plate reader] systems has not been specifically regulated by Council, we've made clear that we believe Flock systems pose an unacceptable risk to the liberty and privacy of our constituents," he told KUT.

The TRUST Act [requires police](#) to submit a formal policy and publicly disclose the use of surveillance technology — even in emergencies.

After KUT asked about its data-sharing with other departments, APD said it was "evaluating its previous policy regarding use of [license plate reader] camera data" and that it was working "to ensure alignment" with the TRUST Act.

Mackenzie Rhine, an attorney and member of the Electronic Frontier Foundation's Austin chapter, was one of dozens of Austinites who spoke out against the cameras at City Hall last year. She said the department's access to Flock is "awful, but I'm not shocked."

"The police chief showed up to these meetings and talked about how much they value privacy and how much they respected our privacy, but it's clear they don't," Rhine said. "They simply don't care about our privacy."

Rhine said she does think the city is moving toward stricter regulation on surveillance technology with the TRUST Act, which she largely supports. She thinks the expanded reporting requirements for surveillance tech could ensure responsible, transparent use by APD, making it less of a "wild west."

Siegel said the department's access to the license plate reader data would violate the TRUST Act, but that he hopes City Council will shore up the loophole to Flock access in the coming weeks as it finalizes the measure.

"I think it's a violation of the intent of council policy," he said. "And that's where we have an opportunity to clean this up in a few weeks before we finalize the TRUST Act ... to make sure this will be covered as well."

Tags

- Crime & Justice
- Austin City Council
- Austin City Hall
- Austin Police Department
- KUT
- Trending



Andrew Weber

Andrew Weber is KUT's government accountability reporter. Got a tip? You can email him at aweber@kut.org. Follow him on Twitter [@England_Weber](https://twitter.com/England_Weber).

[See stories by Andrew Weber](#)

Latest Stories



Education

Austin ISD student is detained by ICE weeks before graduating



Art Beat

City of Austin and public arts community clash over millions in funding



Austin

Austin to explore alternative to IT consolidation after employee, council pushback



Crime & Justice

Austin spends millions on outside attorneys to handle lawsuits

Related Content

Crime & Justice

Austin gives final OK to license plate reader program for police

Andrew Weber, June 9, 2023

Privacy advocates had warned the cameras are akin to a warrantless surveillance program and that the data could be misused. Under the agreement City Council approved, police will hold data from the scanners for just seven days.

Austin

Austin's automatic license plate reader program will end this month

Luz Moreno-Lozano, June 4, 2025

Austin City Council will not vote this week on renewing the program, effectively ending it. The decision came after several community members and city leaders raised concerns about privacy.

Crime & Justice

Austin rejected automatic license plate readers. Advocates want Kyle to do the same.

Maya Fawaz, July 23, 2025

Kyle Police said the devices have helped officers solve crimes, while opponents say there is too much government surveillance for a city of 66,000 people.



Stay Connected

© 2026 KUT Public Media

A service of the Moody College of Communication at the University of Texas at Austin

ABOUT

About Us
Newsroom
Staff
Advisory
Board
News
Releases
Jobs &
Internships

CONNECT

Newsletters
Events
Around the
Station
Mobile Guide
Volunteer
Contact Us

RESOURCES

Schedules
How To Listen
Smart Speakers
Privacy & Terms
Annual EEO
Report (pdf)
CPB Funding
FCC Public File

SUPPORT US

Donate Today
Legacy Planning
Business Circle
Car Donation
Sponsorship
Opportunities
Member Login

